University of Hong Kong
Master of Social Sciences in Sustainability Leadership & Governance
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SLGP7118 Transparency, Accountability and Disclosure (6 Credits)
Course Outline Semestre II 2025-26
Courses Co-ordinator: Dr. Margaret Burnett maggieb@hku.hk

Course Description

Given the importance of standards and guidelines in supporting organizations to adhere to transparency, accountability and disclosure expectations, this course will provide an exploration of the development of standards, guidelines, and frameworks. By exploring the frameworks that have developed in direct response to increased demand for organizational accountability, students will learn about those that have been adopted by organizations that in turn have helped to drive the sustainability agenda. Standards, guidelines and frameworks provide a formula or "way of doing things" that describe or promote continuous learning for best practices and provide a point of reference from which to measure improvements and continuous learning. For example, professional standards provide a practical and ethical framework for decision-making by instilling a sense of responsibility and accountability as well as increasing our knowledge base through experience, continuing professional development; standards for products, processes and outcomes provide reliability of materials, products, methods as well as improved workplace safety. Since the demand for an increased demonstration of responsibility by organizations means improvement in performance against environmental, social and governance measures, this course will explore the growth in the disclosure guidelines and frameworks.
Assessment: 100% coursework

Course Learning Outcomes

1. *Understand the differences between current disclosure standards, guidelines, and frameworks*
2. *Acquire knowledge of the development of reporting, demand for disclosure and listing requirements*
3. *Analyze the rationale for transparency and disclosure as a form of accountability*
4. *Learn concepts such as measure-monitor-manage as technique for performance improvement and continuous learning.*

Course Schedule

DATE	Lecture Topic	Room
Thur 29th Jan 1900-2150	**1. Introduction & context** Thinking critically: ESG – is it here to stay?	KK202
Thu 5th Feb 1900-2150	**2. What and why?** State of play, making connections	KK202
Thur 12th Feb 1900-2150	**3. ESG and Impact** Guest Speaker (TBC)**	KK202
Thur 19th Feb	**No Class**	
Thu 26th Feb 1900-2150	**4. Reporting landscape I** Reporting frameworks overview	KK202
Thur 5th Mar 1900-2150	**5. Reporting landscape II** Reporting frameworks, supporting standards, role of stock exchanges & governance	KK202
Thur 12th Mar 1900-2150	6. **Environmental sustainability** Impact and issues of climate change Guest Speaker (TBC)**	KK202
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Thu 19th Mar 1900-2150	**7. Social Sustainability** Impact and issues from CSR / CSV	
Thu 26th Mar 1900-2150	**8. Materiality** What and how?	KK202
Thu 2nd Apr 1900-2150	**9. Stakeholder Engagement** Why are stakeholders important?	KK202
Thu 9th Apr 1900-2150	**10. Additional standards** e.g., PAS808+ ISO37000	KK202
Thu 16th Apr 1900-2150	**11. Valuing Nature** What is the value of nature to society?	KK202
Thu 23rd Apr 1900-2150	**12. Group presentations** *Please see details below*	KK202

***** Please note that some topics / dates may change due to guest speaker availability***

Course Assessment

Assessments

The various elements of the course are weighted as follows:

Group Project presentation	40%
Individual analysis	60%

1. **Group Analysis of a reporting indicator**
   The class will be divided into groups. The objective is to demonstrate understanding and application of class materials, discussions, background reading and the materials available publicly on the company of choice. No two groups can work on the same company. To facilitate marking, and allow you to integrate any comments from the evening of presentations, please hand in **the presentation materials (power point slides with notes .ppt – soft copy) on the Monday 27th April 2026 uploaded through Moodle**

Groups for the group analysis / presentation to be confirmed after Drop/Add period
Groups will be posted to Moodle
Presentation time ~10 or 15 mins for each group depending on class size

	NAMES	Company	Time (TBD)
G1			6:30-6:45
G2			6:45-7:00
G3			7:00- 7:15
G4			7:15-7:30
G5			7:30 – 7:45
G6			7:45-8:00
G7			8:00 – 8:15
G8			8:15-8:30
G9			8:30 – 8:45

G10			8:45 – 9:00
G11			

You may analyse a company of choice however please submit this choice to the course co-ordinator for approval.

You need to ensure that this company publishes a sustainability report of some kind and has claimed to be aligned with a known reporting framework. Review the materiality process and select the top 3 material issues for each of E, S and G (review industry sector issues, context of the sector, the operating environment of your chosen company), make a comparison to the ones that the company has selected. Use the following to help you assess and discuss:

1. Do you agree that the material issues selected by the company are the most relevant and significant, why?
2. Why did you choose the three that you did, and how are they significant to the company? Did you use a reporting framework to support your choice?
3. How well does the company report on these three aspects / issues? Which framework, if any did they use to support their choice? Is the data (quantitative and qualitative) been consolidated well, and made clear to the reader?
4. What significant action has the company taken to demonstrate real commitment to these issues? Would you say the issues are recognized at the "governance" level?
5. Is the company demonstrating impact?
6. What would you recommend the company do to improve their ability, capacity to disclose to a meaningful level, and discuss what a meaningful level needs to be to move beyond metric reporting?
7. Attempt to give an overall rating of how well the company is performing on the three material issues compared to how well these issues are reported. Using reporting frameworks throughout would be helpful and offering some observations on how each disclosure could be used by a company to their advantage.
8. What are your thoughts on whether they had the report and the data assured / verified.

Your presentation is to be a report to the C-suite, to give them the heads-up on company performance prior to this being reported to the Board. The expectation is for succinct explanations, to-the-point observations, key messages and analyses based on well researched and well-reasoned insights. Keeping in mind, we want companies to move beyond the exercise of reporting information but rather demonstrate performance improvements and ideally positive impact. I'd like to suggest you choose a HKEx listed company and look closely at whether they use only HKEx or combine with other frameworks.

2. Individual exercise

The review and analyses in class will shape the basis of how you will undertake your individual analysis. Quality of the analysis using both in class material, discussion as well as researched background information on the chosen indicator. Keep the scope of the indicator manageable and researchable e.g., climate change is broad whereas energy is more manageable; Occupational Health and Safety (GRI) is broad, worker training is more manageable and Human Capital (SASB) is broad whereas work-related accidents and safety education (SASB) might be more manageable, and you might ask if OSH has been elevated to the governance level?

- Pick one indicator, something you're interested in (keep the scope manageable) and review it across multiple standards / frameworks and evaluate the alignment across the frameworks – similarities or significant differences?
- How aligned is the indicator across your chosen frameworks and is this a positive thing, and could this help or hinder companies to report? Is there overlap, is it large or is the overlap minor?
- What gaps have you found? Does this have the potential to confuse investors / report readers?

- Do they all refer to well recognised methodologies for e.g., data consolidation, calculation?
- What are the strengths and weaknesses of this indicator and what it asks of the reporter? Why would it be important for a company to measure, monitor and manage this indicator?
- Final comment – suggest ways this indicator could be used to demonstrate impact

- Maximum 5-page word document to be fully referenced (quality versus quantity!) Please submit in Word format not pdf
- Individual report due on or before **end of Monday 4th May 2026 and submitted through Turnitin / Moodle**

Important Notice

- **A soft copy of your assignment should be submitted via Moodle before the specified due date.**
- **Marks will be deducted for improper referencing. The sources of quotations, diagrams, tables must be academically referenced and acknowledged for all assignments.**
- **Plagiarism is a serious offence. Any student who commits the offence is liable to disciplinary action.**
- **The use of AI – Given that Turnitin provides an AI usage you are required to add a paragraph at the end of your work indicating how you used AI and which software and for what purpose. Should the Turnitin score be significantly high, you will be asked to provide the supporting notes, your prompts and outcomes, and the original text that was translated or improved by AI.**
- **Unapproved late submission may not be graded.**

Readings and resources **– please also ensure you refer to the course Moodle page**

Relevant frameworks

https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/sustainability-disclosure-requirements-implementation-update-2024
https://finance.ec.europa.eu/capital-markets-union-and-financial-markets/company-reporting-and-auditing/company-reporting/corporate-sustainability-reporting_en#legislation
https://www.globalreporting.org/standards/
https://www.cdp.net/en
https://sasb.ifrs.org/standards/
https://www.ifrs.org/
https://www.skadden.com/insights/publications/2024/05/hkex-publishes-consultation-conclusions

Rankings and ratings

https://www.corporateknights.com
https://www.msci.com/web/msci/esg-ratings
https://www.sustainalytics.com/esg-ratings
https://www.spglobal.com/market-intelligence/en/solutions/sustainability
https://www.morningstar.com/sustainable-investing/morningstar-sustainability-rating-explained
https://www.morningstar.com/sustainable-investing/our-new-rating-measures-stocks-esg-risk

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